

vaginal discharge, and an ointment for hemorrhoids and anal fissures. Internally, bistort may be taken to treat peptic ulcers, ulcerative colitis, and conditions such as dysentery and irritable bowel that give rise to diarrhea.

Related Species *P. hydropiper*, which is native to Europe, may be used to relieve heavy menstrual bleeding. See also knotgrass (*P. aviculare*, preceding entry).

Caution Use bistort internally for no more than 3–4 weeks at a time.

Self-help Use Diarrhea, p. 307.

Polymnia uvedalia (Asteraceae) Bearsfoot

Description Perennial herb growing to 6½ ft (2 m) with large 3-lobed leaves and yellow flowers.

Habitat & Cultivation Bearsfoot is native to the eastern U.S. It grows from New York southward, preferring rich soil. The root is unearthed in autumn.

Part Used Root.

History & Folklore Bearsfoot root was used by Native Americans as a stimulant and laxative remedy. In the 19th century, it became a widely popular healing herb in North America, having a specific use as a treatment for mastitis (inflammation of the breast tissue).

Medicinal Actions & Uses Bearsfoot is perhaps best known for its use as a hair tonic, having traditionally been a popular ingredient in hair lotions. It is still used in this way, but today the root is more often taken internally as a treatment for nonmalignant swollen glands and especially for mastitis. The root is thought to have a beneficial effect on the stomach, liver, and spleen, and may be taken to relieve indigestion and counteract liver malfunction.

Polypodium vulgare (Polypodiaceae) Polypody

Description Delicate perennial fern growing to a height of 1 ft (30 cm). Has slender knotty rhizomes and curving fronds that are dotted with brown spores (sori) on their lower surface.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to Europe and northern Asia, polypody is commonly found growing in damp woodland and hedgerows, and on walls. The rhizome is unearthed in autumn.

Part Used Rhizome.

Constituents Polypody rhizome contains saponins (based on polypodosapogenin), ecdysteroids, phloroglucins, volatile oil, fixed oil, and tannins.

History & Folklore Polypody has been used medicinally in Europe since ancient times. Like mistletoe (*Viscum album*, p. 283), polypody often grows on host trees, for example oak (*Quercus robur*, p. 260). This was thought to impart great medicinal value to the plant. The Greek physician Dioscorides, writing in the 1st century CE, noted that polypody was used to purge phlegm and was an ingredient of a plaster applied to dislocated fingers and to sores that occur between the fingers.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Polypody stimulates bile secretion and has been used to treat such conditions as hepatitis, jaundice, and indigestion. A gentle laxative, polypody makes a safe treatment for constipation in children. The rhizome is also expectorant, having a supportive and mildly stimulating effect on the respiratory system. It may be taken for the relief of congestion, bronchitis, pleurisy, and dry irritable coughs.

Caution Polypody may cause a skin rash when applied externally.



Polypody is often seen growing in damp woodland in Europe and northern Asia.

Pomaderris elliptica (Rhamnaceae) Kumarhou

Description Branching tree growing to about 10 ft (3 m). Has shiny leaves and clusters of yellow-white flowers.

Habitat & Cultivation Kumarhou is native to New Zealand.

Parts Used Aerial parts.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Kumarhou is a traditional Maori remedy that has been used to treat a wide range of illnesses. Its most common use is as a remedy for problems of the respiratory tract, such as asthma and bronchitis. However, it has also been used in the treatment of indigestion and heartburn, diabetes, and kidney problems.

Kumarhou is considered to be a detoxifier and “blood cleansing” plant, and is used to treat skin rashes and sores, including lesions produced by skin cancer.

Populus x candicans syn. *P. x gileadensis* (Salicaceae) Balm of Gilead

Description Deciduous tree growing to 80 ft (25 m). Has heart-shaped leaves, buds producing a sticky resin, and female catkins.

Habitat & Cultivation Naturalized in northern temperate regions, balm of Gilead is also cultivated as an ornamental tree. The buds and bark from young branches are collected in spring.

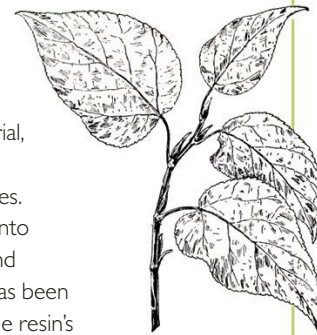
Parts Used Buds, stem bark.

Constituents Balm of Gilead buds contain flavonoids, phenolic glycosides (including salicin), and fatty acids. Salicin's analgesic, anti-inflammatory, and fever-reducing actions resemble those of aspirin. Many poplars have a similar chemical profile and are often used interchangeably as medicines.

History & Folklore Balm of Gilead has been used for several thousand years to soothe inflamed or irritated skin. The 17th-century herbalist Nicholas Culpeper recorded that “The ointment called populeon, which is much of this poplar, is singular for all heat and inflammation in any part of the body and tempereth the heat of wounds: It is much used to dry up the milk in women's breasts.”

Medicinal Actions & Uses Balm of Gilead is a common ingredient of cough mixtures. Its expectorant, antiseptic, and analgesic properties make it an excellent remedy for sore throats, dry irritable coughs, bronchitis, and other respiratory ailments. In France and Germany, balm of Gilead is applied as a salve to scrapes, small wounds, chapped and itchy skin, sunburn, chilblains, and hemorrhoids. A preparation of balm of Gilead, applied externally, may also help relieve the pain of rheumatic joints and strained muscles. As Culpeper noted, the plant is also thought to reduce breast-milk production.

Research Studies have demonstrated that balm of Gilead buds have significant expectorant, antibacterial, antifungal, and anti-inflammatory properties. Research undertaken into the bud resin of this and other poplar species has been prompted largely by the resin's chemical similarity to propolis, a natural antibiotic resin that is gathered by bees.



Balm of Gilead